

CENTRAL EUROPE

THE VERY HEART OF EUROPE consists of a compact block of four countries – Poland, the Czech Republic, Slovakia, and Hungary. This region lies on the north European plain and is largely flat, broken only by low mountains in the south. The country borders within Central Europe have been redrawn many times over the centuries. This is because the flat landscape provides an easy target for invaders, and because the region was surrounded by four mighty empires: Russia, Austro-Hungary, Prussia, and the Ottoman Turks. After World War II, Central Europe came under the control of the former Soviet Union. Now independent, all four countries joined the European Union in 2004.



ROMAN CATHOLICISM
The celebration of saints' days and religious festivals is a regular feature of life in Central Europe, where Roman Catholicism is the main religion. This region was first converted to Christianity about 1,000 years ago. Repeated invasions have led its people to cling to their sense of national identity, and Roman Catholicism is an important part of this.

Each year, thousands of people visit the Black Madonna at Czestochowa, Poland's holiest shrine.



THE DANUBE RIVER

This major waterway links Slovakia and Hungary to Germany and the Rhine River in the west, and to the Black Sea in the southeast. In the past, the Danube has been a vital trading route for Central Europe, although river traffic has declined recently as trade with the former Soviet Union has fallen off sharply. However, the waters have been dammed to produce an important source of hydroelectric power – a dam at Gabčíkovo now provides 15 percent of Slovakia's electricity.



Root vegetables such as beets are used to make thick soups.



Cabbage is very popular and is often eaten stuffed, or pickled as sauerkraut.



Potatoes are served with most main courses.

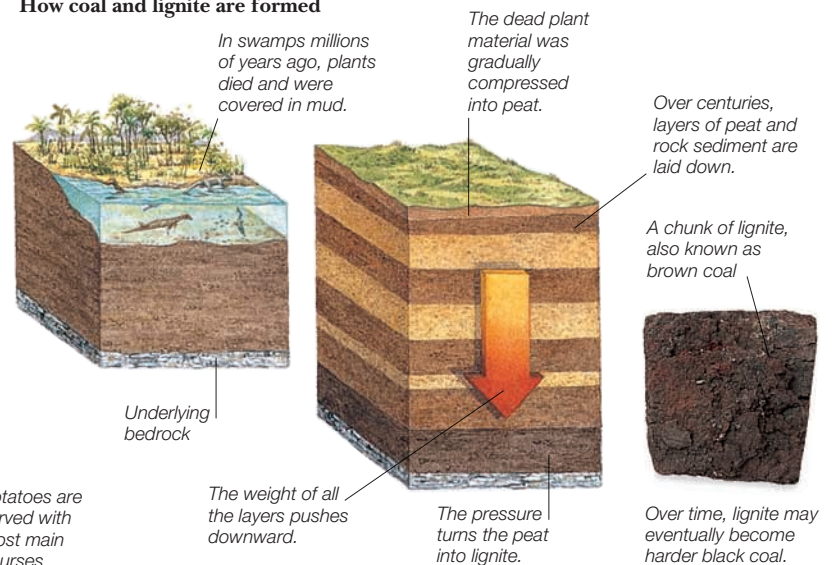


Meat, such as this Polish salt pork called *oczek*, is a central part of most meals.

HEARTY FOOD

The more northerly areas of Central Europe tend to have warm summers but very cold winters. Plummeting temperatures have made heavy, warming foods popular here. Influences are strongly German, Austrian, and Russian, and potatoes, dumplings, soups, and meat stews are favorite dishes. To the south, Hungary has a more exotic tradition, featuring highly spiced foods such as goulash – its famous beef stew.

How coal and lignite are formed



LIGNITE

Brown coal, or lignite, is traditionally the main fuel in Central Europe. It is burned in power plants to produce much of the region's electricity. However, lignite is very rich in sulfur, and, when it is burned, its fumes join with moisture droplets in the air to produce a mild form of sulfuric acid, or "acid rain," which eats into stone buildings and destroys plant life. Air pollution in this region is made even worse by vehicle exhaust fumes – although car ownership is relatively unusual, the cars on the road are frequently old models running on inefficient engines.